

AGES 9–12 · ONE LESSON + A GAME YOU'LL REPLAY ALL YEAR

Is it true? Teaching kids to fact-check AI

The most important AI skill for a 9-to-12-year-old isn't prompting — it's doubting well. AI states wrong things in a confident voice, and kids (like adults) believe confident voices. This lesson gives your learner a three-step check and a game that turns healthy skepticism into a family sport.

THE IDEA, IN KID WORDS

AI is a guessing machine with a confident voice.
A guess is not the same as knowing — so we check.

Teach the three-step check (10 minutes)

- 1 **Does it name a source I could look at?** "Scientists say" isn't a source. A book, a specific website, a person with a name — those can be checked.
- 2 **Can I find it in two other places?** The two-places rule: something true about the world usually shows up in more than one spot — an encyclopedia, a library book, a trusted site.
- 3 **Does it survive the "wait, what?" test?** If a claim is surprising, exciting, or exactly what you hoped was true, it earns extra checking, not less.

The game: Two Truths and an AI

Setup (grown-up, 2 minutes): Using your own AI account, ask: *"Give me two true, surprising, kid-friendly facts about [TOPIC YOUR KID LOVES] and one false fact that sounds just as believable. Don't label which is which."* Print or read them aloud.

Play: Your learner runs the three-step check with real books or a search you supervise, and votes: which one is the fake? Then reveal.

"Notice how the fake one sounded exactly as confident as the real ones? That's the whole lesson. The voice never tells you what's true — checking does."

When they catch a real AI mistake

It will happen — a wrong date, a made-up book title, a mangled fact about their favorite animal. Celebrate it like a goal scored: *"You out-checked the machine."* Kids who've personally caught AI being wrong are permanently harder to fool — by chatbots, by videos, by anything with a confident voice.

House rules that make this stick:

- The grown-up holds the keyboard — chatbot accounts are for 13+; the checking skills are for everyone.
- "Let's check" is said with excitement, never as a gotcha.
- One caught mistake per week gets bragging rights at dinner.

More for this age: our free Family AI Rules poster puts "AI guesses, we check" on the wall — and Launch It, our young-entrepreneur kit for ages 9–12, uses these same checking skills on real business decisions. Both in our TpT store.

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